

Chapter 2 — Kings and Kingdoms

The one-line point: After the seventh century, **subordinates kept becoming kings**. This chapter is about how they pulled it off — the rituals, the titles, the taxes, the temples — and it ends with the **Cholas**, the most sophisticated state in the subcontinent.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Early Medieval India
Sub-discipline	State formation & regional kingdoms (the "early medieval" polity debate)
Period	7th – 12th centuries CE
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → dynasties, tripartite struggle, Chola administration
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ <i>Art forms & architecture</i> — Chola temples and bronzes ; also state formation
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★ ★ ★ (Chola bronzes, Dravida temples), Polity ★ ★ ★ (Uttaramerur — local self-government), Economy (land grants, taxation), Geography (Kaveri delta irrigation)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ — the Cholas carry most of it
Overlaps with	Class 6 Ch.9 (this is the <i>same</i> Uttaramerur inscription, and the same tripartite struggle)

 **Early Medieval India.** For Mains its home is **Art & Culture** (Chola bronzes) and **Polity** (village assemblies).

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** how *samantas* became independent kings, and define *maha-samanta* and *maha-mandaleshvara*.
- ☐ **Describe** the *hiranya-garbha* ritual and explain precisely what it was for. ★
- ☐ **Name** two Brahmanas who founded kingdoms by taking to arms.
- ☐ **List** the grand royal titles and explain why they overstate real power.
- ☐ **Define** *vetti* and *kadamai* and state how many tax terms Chola inscriptions mention.
- ☐ **Explain** what a *prashasti* is, cite the **Nagabhata/Gwalior** example, and state its limits as a source.
- ☐ **Identify** the three parties to the **tripartite struggle** and the prize.
- ☐ **State** the facts about **Mahmud of Ghazni** — dates, number of raids, targets.
- ☐ **Narrate** the **Prithviraja III vs Muhammad Ghori** encounters with correct years. ★
- ☐ **Trace** the Chola rise from the **Muttaraiyar** to **Rajendra I**.
- ☐ **Describe** Chola temples and **bronze sculpture**, and explain why temples were economic centres.

- ☐ Define *ur**, *nadu*, *sabha*, **nagaram*, and the five Chola land categories.
- ☐ Reproduce the **Uttaramerur** qualification and disqualification rules. ★
- ☐ Explain what the *Periyapuranam* adds that inscriptions leave out. ★

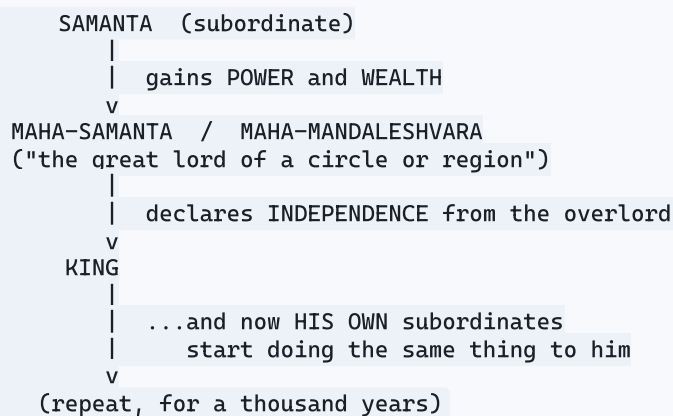
Start Here: The Promotion Problem

By the seventh century there were **big landlords and warrior chiefs** everywhere. Existing kings acknowledged them as subordinates — **samantas**.

A samanta's obligations:

- Bring **gifts** for his king or overlord
- Be **present at his court**
- Provide **military support**

And then the pattern that defines the whole chapter:



 **This is privilege escalation as a governance model.** The overlord delegates authority and resources to a subordinate in order to extend reach; the subordinate accumulates enough of both to stop needing the overlord. There is **no mechanism to revoke the grant**, so every delegation is potentially permanent. You saw the identical dynamic in **Class 6 Ch.9** with *samantas* and land grants under the Guptas — this chapter is that process running to completion.

1 The Emergence of New Dynasties

Case study: the Rashtrakutas ★★

Step	Detail
Starting position	Subordinate to the Chalukyas of Karnataka
The move	In the mid-eighth century , Dantidurga , a Rashtrakuta chief, overthrew his Chalukya overlord
The legitimization	He performed a ritual called HIRANYA-GARBHA — literally " the golden womb "
What it did	Performed with the help of Brahmanas , it was thought to lead to the " rebirth " of the sacrificer as a Kshatriya — ★ even if he was not one by birth

★★ **Hiranya-garbha** is the single most important term in this chapter. Understand what it reveals: **Kshatriya status was not purely hereditary — it could be acquired**, provided you had the power to command Brahmanas to certify it.

🔑 **The bargain, again:** the ruler gets caste legitimacy; the Brahmanas get gifts, land and confirmation that **only they can confer such status**. This is the same king–priest exchange you saw in the Ashvamedha (Class 6 Ch.5) and in temple patronage (Ch.1 of this book).

🗡️ Brahmanas who became kings ★

Two men NCERT names explicitly — both **Brahmanas who gave up their traditional professions and took to arms:**

Person	Dynasty founded	Region
Mayurasharman	Kadamba	Karnataka
Harichandra	Gurjara-Pratihara	Rajasthan

🎯 NCERT's question is the exam-relevant one: *was being born a Kshatriya important in order to become a ruler in this period?* **The answer the evidence gives is no.** Military success plus ritual certification did the job. Excellent for a Mains point about social mobility in early medieval India.

2 Administration in the Kingdoms

Grand titles, shared power

New kings adopted **high-sounding titles**:

Title	Meaning
Maharaja-adhiraja	Great king, overlord of kings
Tribhuvana-chakravartin	Lord of the three worlds

⚠️ **But NCERT immediately punctures this:** *"in spite of such claims, they often **shared power** with their samantas as well as with **associations of peasants, traders and Brahmanas.**"*

🎯 **This is the key analytical point of the section.** Early medieval kingship was **not absolute**. The grand title and the actual distribution of power point in opposite directions — and reading the title as evidence of the power is exactly the mistake the prashasti section warns about.

💰 Resources and taxation

Resources were obtained from **producers — peasants, cattle-keepers, artisans** — who were *"persuaded or compelled"* to surrender a part of what they produced. This was claimed as **"rent" due to a lord who asserted that he owned the land**. Revenue was also collected from **traders**.

★★ **Four hundred taxes!**

Fact	Detail
Chola inscriptions refer to more than 400 terms for different kinds of taxes	
★ VETTI — the most frequently mentioned; taken not in cash but as FORCED LABOUR	
★ KADAMAI — land revenue	
Others	Taxes on thatching the house , on the use of a ladder to climb palm trees , a cess on succession to family property

💡 **The palm-tree-ladder tax is worth remembering** — it's the detail that makes the scale of medieval fiscal reach concrete and memorable. Over 400 categories means an administration that had thought very hard about extracting value from every activity.

What the revenue funded: the king's establishment, and the **construction of temples and forts**. Kings also **waged war**, expected to yield **plunder** and access to **land and trade routes**.

Who collected it: functionaries recruited from **influential families**, and **positions were often hereditary** — true of the army as well. In many cases **close relatives of the king** held these positions.

📖 **Hereditary office again.** As in Class 6 Ch.9, paying officials with position rather than salary means the state gradually loses the ability to reassign them. Cheap to run, impossible to reform.

3 Prashastis and Land Grants

📖 Prashastis

A **prashasti** contains details that **may not be literally true**. But it tells us **how rulers wanted to depict themselves** — as valiant, victorious warriors. Composed by **learned Brahmanas**, who occasionally helped in the administration.

★ **The Gwalior prashasti of Nagabhata** (a **Pratihara** king), in **Sanskrit**, found in **Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh**, claims he defeated the kings of:

Claimed defeated	Region
Andhra	Andhra
Saindhava	Sind
Vidarbha	Part of Maharashtra
Kalinga	Part of Odisha
Chakrayudha	Ruler of Kanauj
Vanga	Part of Bengal
Anarta	Part of Gujarat
Malava	Part of Madhya Pradesh
Kirata	Forest peoples
Turushka	Turks
Vatsa, Matsya	Kingdoms in north India

🔗 Same genre as Class 6 Ch.9's Prayag Prashasti of Samudragupta. Same caution applies: **facts usable, evaluations not.**

📄 Land grants on copper plates

Kings rewarded **Brahmanas** with grants of land, **recorded on copper plates** given to the recipient. The plates were **held together by a ring secured with the royal seal**, to indicate an authentic document.

★ **What a Chola land grant actually conveyed** — this excerpt is worth knowing because it shows the *scope* of what was handed over:

BOUNDARIES marked by earthen embankments and thorny bushes.

THE LAND CONTAINS:

fruit-bearing trees | water | land | gardens and orchards
trees | wells | open spaces | pasture-land | a village
anthills | platforms | canals | ditches | deep lakes

THE RECIPIENT MAY:

- > COLLECT TAXES from it (including on betel-leaves, woven cloth, and vehicles)
- > build large rooms with UPPER STOREYS of baked brick
- > get large and small WELLS dug
- > plant trees and thorny bushes
- > construct CANALS for irrigation
- > (and must ensure water is not wasted, and embankments are built)

🎯 **Read what's really being transferred:** not just soil, but **the right to tax, to build, to irrigate — and a village with people in it.** This is the transfer of governance itself, which is exactly why land grants hollowed out central authority over time.

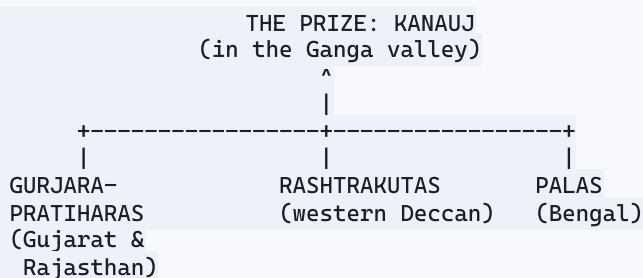
📖 Kalhana's *Rajatarangini* ★★

Aspect	Detail
What	A Sanskrit poem containing the history of the kings who ruled over Kashmir
Author	Kalhana (12th century)
Sources he used	Inscriptions, documents, eyewitness accounts and earlier histories
★ Why he matters	Unlike the writers of prashastis, he was often CRITICAL about rulers and their policies

★ **This is a high-frequency Prelims fact and a great Mains point.** Kalhana is usually described as the closest thing early India has to a critical historian — he used multiple source types and evaluated rulers rather than praising them. When a question contrasts "eulogy" with "history", *Rajatarangini* is the example.

4 Warfare for Wealth

🏰 The Tripartite Struggle ★★



Because there were THREE parties, historians call it the "TRIPARTITE STRUGGLE".

Why Kanauj? It commanded the **fertile Ganga valley** — the richest agricultural region, and the symbolic key to north Indian paramourcy (the same role it plays in Class 6 Ch.9, after Harsha).

🔗 **Direct continuity with Class 6 Ch.9** — the tripartite struggle was introduced there. Same three powers, same prize. **If you can narrate it from both books, you've genuinely joined the two.**

🏰 Temples as targets

Rulers demonstrated power and resources by **building large temples**. So when they attacked one another's kingdoms, **they often chose to target temples, which were sometimes extremely rich**.

🔑 **The logic to grasp:** a temple was simultaneously a **religious centre, a treasury, and a statement of the ruler's legitimacy**. Destroying or looting one struck all three at once. **Temple attacks in this period were as much political and economic as religious** — an important nuance, and one NCERT is making deliberately.

🏰 Mahmud of Ghazni ★★

Fact	Detail
From	Ghazni, Afghanistan
Raids	17 times, between 1000 and 1025 ★
Targets	Wealthy temples, including Somnath in Gujarat ★
What he did with the wealth	Used it to create a splendid capital city at Ghazni

⚠️ **A note on motive, handled carefully.** The current NCERT text says he raided "with a religious motive"; older editions and most academic scholarship emphasise **plunder** — the wealth funded Ghazni, and he did not attempt to hold Indian territory or convert it. **For an exam, state the facts (17 raids, 1000–1025, Somnath, wealth taken to Ghazni) and note that motives are debated between iconoclasm and plunder.** That is both accurate and safe.

💡 **Worth knowing beyond the text:** Mahmud's court patronised **al-Biruni**, the Central Asian scholar who wrote the *Kitab-ul-Hind* (*Tahqiq-i Hind*) — a remarkably careful study of Indian society, science and religion. It's a standard Prelims name and is not in the rationalised chapter, so learn it here.

🐉 The Chahamanas and Prithviraja III ★★

Fact	Detail
Who	The Chahamanas , later known as the Chauhans
Where	The region around Delhi and Ajmer ★ (their two major cities)
Expansion	Tried to expand west and east — opposed by the Chalukyas of Gujarat and the Gahadavalas of western Uttar Pradesh
Best-known ruler	PRITHVIRAJA III (1168–1192)
★★ The two battles	Defeated Sultan Muhammad Ghori in 1191 — but lost to him the very next year, in 1192

🧠 **Memory hook: "91 win, 92 loss."** Tarain 1191 and Tarain 1192 (the battle names aren't in this chapter but are standard). **The 1192 defeat opens the door to Chapter 3** — the Delhi Sultanate begins directly from it.

5 ★★ A Closer Look: THE CHOLAS

The most important section of the chapter.

📄 From Uraiyur to Thanjavur

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MUTTARAIYAR
(a minor chiefly family holding power in the KAVERI DELTA,
 subordinate to the PALLAVA kings of KANCHIPURAM)
    |
    | mid-NINTH century: VIJAYALAYA, of the
    | ancient Chola family from URAIYUR,
    | CAPTURES the delta from them
    v
VIJAYALAYA --> builds the town of THANJAVUR
                and a temple for the goddess NISHUMBHASUDINI
    |
    v
His successors conquer neighbouring regions;
PANDYAN and PALLAVA territories (south and north)
absorbed into the kingdom
    |
    v
RAJARAJA I -- the most powerful Chola ruler; became king in 985;
              expanded control and REORGANISED the administration
    |
    v
RAJENDRA I -- continued his father's policies;
              expeditions to the GANGA valley, SRI LANKA and
              SOUTH-EAST ASIA; developed a NAVY

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★ **Key names to fix:** **Muttaraiyar** (displaced), **Pallavas of Kanchipuram** (their overlords), **Vijayalaya** (founder, from **Uraiyur**, built **Thanjavur** + **Nishumbhasudini** temple), **Rajaraja I** (985, most powerful), **Rajendra I** (Ganga + naval expeditions).

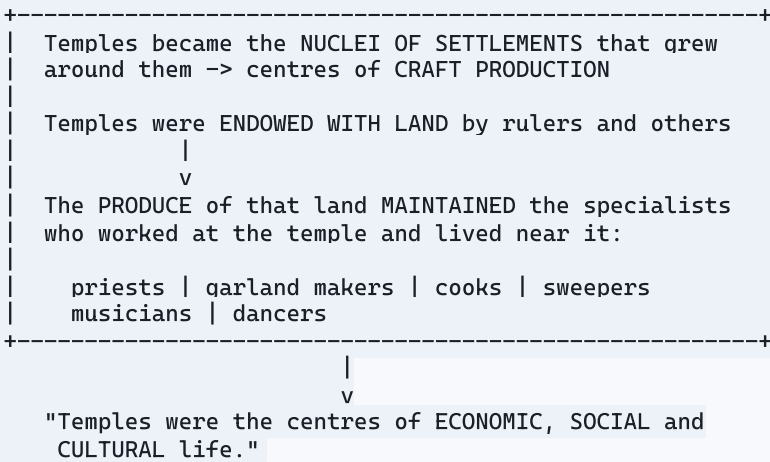
🏛️ Splendid temples and bronze sculpture ★★★

Temple	Built by
Thanjavur (Brihadeshwara)	Rajaraja I
Gangaikondacholapuram	Rajendra I

Both are described as "**architectural and sculptural marvels**" — note the **tapering roof (vimana)** and the **elaborate stone sculptures** decorating the outer walls.

★ ★ **Why temples mattered economically — this is the exam point:**

A CHOLA TEMPLE WAS NOT ONLY A PLACE OF WORSHIP.



 **A temple was an endowed institution running a local economy** — land generating perpetual income, supporting a permanent staff with specialised roles, anchoring a settlement, and producing crafts. Compare the *shreni* endowments of Class 6 Ch.8: same financial instrument, larger scale.

★ **CHOLA BRONZES**

Amongst the crafts associated with temples, **the making of bronze images was the most distinctive. Chola bronze images are considered amongst the finest in the world.** While most images were of deities, **sometimes images were made of devotees as well.**

 **Very high Art & Culture yield.** Made by the **lost-wax (cire perdue) process** — the same technique as the Harappan Dancing Girl (Class 6 Ch.3), which makes a lovely 3,000-year continuity point. The **Nataraja** (Shiva as lord of dance) is the iconic Chola bronze. **Learn: Chola + bronze + lost-wax + Nataraja.**

 Agriculture and irrigation

The **Kaveri** branches into several small channels before emptying into the Bay of Bengal, **overflowing frequently and depositing fertile soil.** Water from the channels provides moisture for agriculture, **particularly rice.**

The work required

Forests cleared in some regions; **land levelled** in others

In the delta, **embankments** built to prevent flooding, and **canals** constructed to carry water

Where nature wasn't enough: **wells dug**, and **huge tanks constructed to collect rainwater**

★ A **sluice gate** — a wood or metal barrier controlling water levels — regulated flow from a tank into irrigation channels (a **ninth-century** example survives in Tamil Nadu)

🔑 **NCERT's point about irrigation is institutional, not technical:** "*irrigation works require planning — **organising labour and resources, maintaining these works, and deciding how water is to be shared.***" **Water management is a governance problem.** Both rulers and villagers took an active interest. **This is a strong, concrete example for a Mains answer on water governance.**

📁 ★★ ★ The Administration of the Empire

Settlement hierarchy:

Unit	Meaning
UR	A settlement of peasants , which became prosperous with the spread of irrigated agriculture
NADU	A group of such villages
SABHA	Assembly of a brahmadeya village (see below)
NAGARAM	Associations of traders , which occasionally performed administrative functions in towns

The **village council** and the **nadu** performed several administrative functions — **dispensing justice and collecting taxes.**

Rich peasants exercised considerable control over the affairs of the *nadu*, under the supervision of the central Chola government. The kings gave rich landowners **titles as markers of respect**, and entrusted them with important offices:

Title	Meaning
Muvendavelan ★	"A velan (peasant) serving three kings "
Araiyar	Chief

★★ ★ The five categories of land (from Chola inscriptions):

Term	Meaning
vellanvagai	Land of non-Brahmana peasant proprietors
brahmadeya	Land gifted to Brahmanas
shalabhoga	Land for the maintenance of a school ★
devadana* , *tirunamattukkani	Land gifted to temples
pallichchhandam	Land donated to Jaina institutions ★

🧠 **Memory hooks:** *shala*-bhoga → *shala* = **school**. *Palli*-chchhandam → *palli* = a **Jaina** (or Buddhist) establishment. *Vellan*-vagai → *vellalar* were the **non-Brahmana landowners** (Class 6 Ch.8!).

Each **brahmadeya** was looked after by a **sabha** of prominent **Brahmana landholders**, whose decisions were **recorded in detail in inscriptions, often on the stone walls of temples.**

🏛️ ★★ ★ The Uttaramerur Inscription

From Uttaramerur, Chingleput district, Tamil Nadu. You met this in **Class 6 Ch.9** — here is the fuller detail.

How the sabha was organised: it had **separate committees** to look after **irrigation works, gardens, temples, etc.**

The selection method — *kudavolai*:

1. Names of those eligible are written on SMALL TICKETS OF PALM LEAF
2. The tickets are put into an EARTHENWARE POT
3. A YOUNG BOY is asked to draw the tickets out, ONE BY ONE, for each committee

★ The rules, as the inscription lays them down:

✓ To be a member you must	✗ You are disqualified if
Be an owner of land from which land revenue is collected	You have been a member of any committee in the last three years ★
Have your own home	You (or your relatives) have not submitted your accounts ★
Be between 35 and 70 years of age	
Have knowledge of the Vedas	
Be well-versed in administrative matters and honest	

🎯 Why this earns marks in a governance answer: eligibility criteria, an **anti-incumbency/rotation rule**, and **mandatory audit enforced by disqualification** — in a tenth-century village inscription.

⚠️ And the honest caveat, as always: membership required being a **male, propertied, Veda-learned landholder. Sophisticated local self-government, not universal franchise.** NCERT itself asks the pointed question: *"Do you think women participated in these assemblies?"*

🔗 The full lineage for GS2: Vajji gana-sangha (Cl.6 Ch.5) → Buddhist sangha procedure (Cl.6 Ch.6) → Chola sabha / Uttaramerur (Cl.6 Ch.9 + here) → 73rd/74th Amendments.

👥 ★ What the inscriptions leave out — the *Periyapuranam*

NCERT makes a deliberate methodological point by setting a **twelfth-century Tamil work, the *Periyapuranam***, against the inscriptions.

"While inscriptions tell us about kings and powerful men," the Periyapuranam informs us about the lives of ordinary men and women.

Its description of a hamlet of **Pulaiyas** — a name used for a social group considered **"outcastes"** by **Brahmanas and Vellalas** — records:

- Small huts under old thatches, thresholds covered with strips of leather
- **Agrarian labourers engaged in menial occupations**
- Children wearing **bracelets of black iron**
- A **female labourer putting her baby to sleep on a sheet of leather**
- **Pulaiyar men** called to work by cocks crowing before dawn
- **Pulaiya women singing as they husked paddy**

★★ NCERT's own question is the exam-worthy one: *"Why do you think temple inscriptions ignore these activities?"*

Because inscriptions were commissioned by those with the means and the motive to **commission them** — kings, Brahmana landholders, temples. The labourers who husked the paddy and built the embankments had neither. **This is Class 6 Chapter 1's "silence of the sources" lesson, restated with a concrete case.** It is outstanding material for any Mains answer on marginalised histories or on the limits of epigraphic evidence.

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Samanta → maha-samanta → maha-mandaleshvara ★	The escalation ladder
Hiranya-garbha ★★★	"Golden womb"; Dantidurga, Rashtrakuta, mid-8th c. ; rebirth as Kshatriya
Brahmana kingdom-founders ★	Mayurasharma (Kadamba, Karnataka), Harichandra (Gurjara-Pratihara, Rajasthan)
Titles	<i>Maharaja-adhiraja, tribhuvana-chakravartin</i>
Vetti* / *kadamai ★★	Forced labour / land revenue; 400+ tax terms
Nagabhata prashasti	Pratihara; Gwalior ; Sanskrit
Rajatarangini ★★	Kalhana ; Kashmir; used varied sources; critical of rulers
Tripartite struggle ★★ ★	Gurjara-Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas, Palas for Kanauj
Mahmud of Ghazni ★★	17 raids, 1000–1025; Somnath ; wealth to Ghazni; patron of al-Biruni (<i>Kitab-ul-Hind</i>)
Chahamanas/Chauhans ★	Delhi and Ajmer; Prithviraja III (1168–1192) ; beat Ghori 1191 , lost 1192
Chola rise ★★	Muttaraiyar ← Pallavas of Kanchipuram ; Vijayalaya from Uraiyur ; Thanjavur + Nishumbhasudini
Rajaraja I / Rajendra I ★★	985; reorganised administration / Ganga + naval expeditions
Temples ★★	Thanjavur (Rajaraja), Gangaikondacholapuram (Rajendra)
Chola bronzes ★★ ★	Finest in the world; lost-wax ; Nataraja ; sometimes devotees depicted
Ur* / nadu / sabha / *nagaram ★★ ★	Peasant village / group of villages / brahmadeya assembly / traders' association
Land types ★★	<i>vellanvagai, brahmadeya, shalabhoga (school), devadana/tirunamattukkani (temple), pallichchhandam (Jaina)</i>
Titles for landowners	Muvendavelan, araiyar
Uttamerur ★★ ★	Palm-leaf tickets, pot, young boy; 35–70 , land, home, Vedas; 3-year bar, accounts
Periyapuram ★★	12th-c. Tamil; lives of ordinary men and women ; Pulaiyas
Sluice gate	9th-century, Tamil Nadu; regulated tank-to-channel flow

Traps:

- "Kshatriya birth was essential to become a ruler" → **FALSE**. *Hiranya-garbha*; Brahmana founders
- "The sabha was the assembly of an ordinary village" → **FALSE**. That's the *ur*; *sabha* = **brahmadeya**
- "Prithviraja III defeated Muhammad Ghori and was never defeated by him" → **FALSE**. Won **1191**, lost **1192**
- "Kalhana wrote a prashasti praising Kashmir's kings" → **FALSE**. He was **critical** of rulers
- "Shalabhoga was land granted to temples" → **FALSE**. Land for a **school**
- "Mahmud of Ghazni established an empire in India" → **FALSE**. He **raided** and withdrew

Mains

- **Art & Culture** ★ ★ ★: "Chola bronzes represent the high point of Indian metal sculpture." — lost-wax technique, Nataraja, temple context, devotee images
- **Art & Culture:** Chola temples as **economic and social institutions**, not merely religious ones
- **Polity/Governance** ★ ★ ★: **Uttaramerur** and Chola local self-government as the lineage of Panchayati Raj — with the exclusion caveat
- **State formation:** "Early medieval kingship was shared rather than absolute." Use samantas, associations of peasants/traders/Brahmanas, and hereditary offices
- **Source criticism** ★: the **inscription vs Periyapuramam** contrast — what epigraphy systematically omits

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Samanta	A subordinate lord owing gifts, attendance and military support
Maha-samanta / Maha-mandaleshvara	"Great lord of a circle/region" — a samanta asserting higher status
Hiranya-garbha	"Golden womb" ritual; conferred Kshatriya status
Maharaja-adhiraja	Great king, overlord of kings
Tribhuvana-chakravartin	Lord of the three worlds
Vetti	Tax taken as forced labour
Kadamai	Land revenue
Prashasti	Eulogistic inscription praising a ruler
Rajatarangini	Kalhana's history of Kashmir's kings
Ur	A settlement of peasants
Nadu	A group of villages
Sabha	Assembly of a brahmadeya village
Nagaram	Association of traders
Muvendavelan	"Peasant serving three kings" — an honorific
Araiyar	Chief
Vellanvagai	Land of non-Brahmana peasant proprietors
Brahmadeya	Land gifted to Brahmanas
Shalabhoga	Land for the maintenance of a school
Devadana / Tirunamattukkani	Land gifted to temples
Pallichchhandam	Land donated to Jaina institutions
Kudavolai	The palm-leaf-ticket-in-a-pot selection method
Sluice gate	Barrier controlling water flow from a tank
Periyapuramam	12th-century Tamil text describing ordinary lives

90-Second Recap

1. **Samantas became kings.** Gaining wealth and power, they took titles like *maha-mandaleshvara* and declared independence.
 2. **Dantidurga (Rashtrakuta)** overthrew his **Chalukya** overlord in the mid-8th century and performed **hiranya-garbha** — the "golden womb" ritual that conferred **Kshatriya status on someone not born to it**.
 3. **Brahmanas founded kingdoms too** — **Mayurasharman** (Kadamba) and **Harichandra** (Gurjara-Pratihara).
 4. Kings took grand titles but **shared power** with samantas and with associations of peasants, traders and Brahmanas.
 5. **Over 400 tax terms** in Chola inscriptions; **vetti** = forced labour, **kadamai** = land revenue. Offices were **hereditary**.
 6. **Prashastis** show how rulers wished to be seen (**Nagabhata**, Gwalior). **Kalhana's Rajatarangini** is the opposite — **critical** of rulers.
 7. **Land grants on copper plates** transferred not just soil but **the right to tax, build and irrigate**.
 8. **Tripartite struggle: Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas, Palas for Kanauj.** Temples were targeted because they were **rich and symbolically central**.
 9. **Mahmud of Ghazni: 17 raids, 1000–1025, Somnath**, wealth to Ghazni.
 10. **Prithviraja III beat Muhammad Ghori in 1191 and lost in 1192** — which opens Chapter 3.
 11. **Cholas: Vijayalaya** (from Uraiyur) took the Kaveri delta from the **Muttaraiyar**, built **Thanjavur**; **Rajaraja I** (985) reorganised the empire; **Rajendra I** sent expeditions to the Ganga, Sri Lanka and South-East Asia and built a **navy**.
 12. **Chola temples** (Thanjavur, Gangaikondacholapuram) were **economic and social centres** with endowed land supporting priests, cooks, musicians and dancers. **Chola bronzes are among the finest in the world**.
 13. **Administration: ur** (peasant village), **nadu** (group), **sabha** (brahmadeya), **nagaram** (traders); five land categories including **shalabhoga** (school) and **pallichchhandam** (Jaina).
 14. **Uttaramerur**: committee members drawn by **lot from a pot**, with property, age (**35–70**), Vedic and honesty qualifications, a **3-year bar** and **compulsory accounts**.
 15. **The Periyapuramam** records the **Pulaiya labourers** whom the inscriptions ignore — the chapter's own lesson in the silence of sources.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. The ritual of *hiranya-garbha* was performed in order to — → *Confer Kshatriya status on a person not born a Kshatriya; famously by Dantidurga of the Rashtrakutas.*
2. Consider the following pairs:
 1. Vetti — forced labour
 2. Kadamai — land revenue
 3. Shalabhoga — land gifted to temples → *1 and 2 only. Shalabhoga maintained a **school**; temple land was devadana/tirunamattukkani.*
3. The parties to the "tripartite struggle" were — → *The Gurjara-Pratiharas, the Rashtrakutas and the Palas, contending for Kanauj.*

4. Consider the following statements about Kalhana's *Rajatarangini*:

1. It is a Sanskrit poem on the kings of Kashmir.
2. Its author used inscriptions, documents and eyewitness accounts.
3. It follows the conventions of prashasti in praising rulers. → 1 and 2 only. Kalhana was often **critical** of rulers.

5. Which pair is correctly matched?

1. Vijayalaya — captured the Kaveri delta from the Muttaraiyar
2. Rajaraja I — built the temple at Gangaikondacholapuram → Only 1. Gangaikondacholapuram was built by **Rajendra I**; Rajaraja built Thanjavur.

6. In Chola administration, a *nagaram* was — → An association of traders, which sometimes performed administrative functions in towns.

Mains style

7. "In early medieval India, kingship was shared rather than absolute." Examine. **(250 words)**
8. Discuss the role of the temple in the economic and social life of the Chola kingdom. **(250 words)**
9. "The Chola system of local self-government anticipated modern representative principles without their inclusiveness." Comment. **(150 words)**
10. "Inscriptions tell us about kings; literature tells us about everyone else." Discuss with reference to Chola-period sources. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- What was *hiranya-garbha* and what problem did it solve?
- Name the three parties and the prize in the tripartite struggle.
- Give the two dates for Prithviraja III and Muhammad Ghori.
- Define *ur*, *nadu*, *sabha* and *nagaram*.
- List the five Chola land categories.
- State three qualifications and two disqualifications from the Uttaramerur inscription.
- What does the *Periyapuranam* tell us that inscriptions do not, and why?